

## Primary Source Reading: Plato's *Protagoras* — Justice as a Gift to All

*Philosophy Honors: Ethics / Lesson 1.04 — Is Morality Just Our Custom? Translated by Benjamin Jowett*

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**Before you read:** This reading gives you Protagoras's own account of where justice comes from — the strongest ancient statement of the view that morality is a human institution, not a discovery about the world. As you read, notice exactly what Protagoras claims: not that different cities happen to have different rules, but that punishment itself proves virtue is teachable rather than natural.

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### The Myth: Zeus Gives Justice to All

Zeus feared that the entire race would be exterminated, and so he sent Hermes to them, bearing reverence and justice to be the ordering principles of cities and the bonds of friendship and conciliation. Hermes asked Zeus how he should impart justice and reverence among men: — Should he distribute them as the arts are distributed; that is to say, to a favoured few only, one skilled individual having enough of medicine or of any other art for many unskilled ones? “Shall this be the manner in which I am to distribute justice and reverence among men, or shall I give them to all?” “To all,” said Zeus; “I should like them all to have a share; for cities cannot exist, if a few only share in the virtues, as in the arts. And further, make a law by my order, that he who has no part in reverence and justice shall be put to death, for he is a plague of the state.”

### Punishment as Proof That Virtue Is Taught

No one would instruct, no one would rebuke, or be angry with those whose calamities they suppose to be due to nature or chance; they do not try to punish or to prevent them from being what they are; they do but pity them. Who is so foolish as to chastise or instruct the ugly, or the diminutive, or the feeble? And for this reason: because he knows that good and evil of this kind is the work of nature and of chance; whereas if a man is wanting in those good qualities which are attained by study and exercise and teaching, and has only the contrary evil qualities, other men are angry with him, and punish and reprove him — of these evil qualities one is impiety, another injustice, and they may be described generally as the very opposite of political virtue. In such cases any man will be angry with another, and reprimand him, — clearly because he thinks that by study and learning, the virtue in which the other is deficient may be acquired. If you will think, Socrates, of the nature of punishment, you will see at once that in the opinion of mankind virtue may be acquired.

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**After you read:** Notice the structure of Protagoras's argument. He does not simply assert that virtue is a matter of custom — he argues for it, using an observation about how punishment actually works: we punish natural defects with pity, not anger, but we punish injustice with anger and correction, which only makes sense if we think the person could have learned to be otherwise. As you prepare for the essay assignment, ask whether this argument really supports full-blown relativism (the view that there is no truth about justice beyond what each culture decides) or something more modest — that virtue is *acquired* rather than innate, which is a different claim entirely.